e-ISSN: 2582-5208
International Research Journal of Modernization in Engineering Technology and Science
(Peer-Reviewed, Open Access, Fully Refereed International Journal)
Volume:08/Issue:05/May-2026 Impact Factor- 8.187 www.irjmets.com

MULTIMODAL DEEP LEARNING FOR HATE SPEECH DETECTION ON SOCIAL MEDIA: INTEGRATING TEXTUAL AND VISUAL FEATURES

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DOI: https://www.doi.org/10.56726/IRJMETS96773

ABSTRACT

The rapid growth of social media platforms has significantly increased the spread of hate speech, leading to online harassment and serious societal consequences. Traditional hate speech detection approaches primarily rely on textual analysis, often neglecting the visual information that accompanies harmful content and plays a crucial role in deception. To address this limitation, this paper proposes a **multimodal deep learning framework** that integrates both **textual and visual features** for accurate hate speech detection. The textual modality is processed using a hybrid **CNN–BiLSTM network** to capture local semantic patterns and long-range contextual dependencies, while the visual modality employs a **pre-trained convolutional neural network** to extract discriminative image features. The extracted features from both modalities are fused at the feature level and passed through fully connected layers for final classification. Experiments conducted on a publicly available multimodal hate speech dataset demonstrate that the proposed multimodal approach outperforms unimodal models in terms of accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-score. The results highlight the effectiveness of combining textual and visual information, making the proposed system a robust and reliable solution for hate speech detection on social media platforms.

Keywords Hate Speech Detection, Multimodal Learning, Deep Learning, CNN, BiLSTM, Image Analysis, Social Media.

I. INTRODUCTION

The widespread adoption of social media platforms such as Twitter, Facebook, and Instagram has revolutionized the way information is created, shared, and consumed. While these platforms enable rapid dissemination of ideas and opinions, they have also become fertile ground for the spread of **hate speech**, which refers to deliberately abusive or threatening content targeting individuals or groups based on protected characteristics such as race, religion, gender, or ethnicity. Hate speech can incite real-world violence, damage reputations, marginalize communities, and threaten social harmony. As a result, the automatic detection of hate speech has emerged as a critical research problem in the fields of **artificial intelligence, natural language processing, and multimedia analysis**.

Early approaches to hate speech detection primarily relied on **manual moderation** or rule-based systems, which are time-consuming, subjective, and incapable of handling the massive volume of online content. With the advancement of machine learning, researchers proposed automated classification models using linguistic features, sentiment analysis, and traditional classifiers such as Support Vector Machines and Naïve Bayes. Although these methods achieved moderate success, they heavily depended on handcrafted features and lacked the ability to generalize across diverse content types and writing styles.

Recent progress in **deep learning** has significantly improved hate speech detection performance by enabling automatic feature extraction from raw data. Deep neural networks such as Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) and Recurrent Neural Networks (RNNs), particularly Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) and Bidirectional LSTM (BiLSTM), have been widely used to model semantic patterns and contextual dependencies in harmful text. However, a major limitation of most existing deep learning-based approaches is their **exclusive reliance on textual information**. In real-world scenarios, hateful posts on social media are often accompanied by **images** that are intentionally manipulated, misleading, or taken out of context to reinforce harmful narratives.

Ignoring visual information can significantly reduce detection accuracy, as images often carry strong emotional and inflammatory cues that complement textual expressions of hate. To overcome this limitation, researchers have begun exploring **multimodal hate speech detection**, which combines multiple sources of information—most commonly text and images—to improve classification robustness. Multimodal learning leverages the complementary nature of different data modalities, enabling models to capture richer and more discriminative representations of harmful content.

Despite its potential, multimodal hate speech detection presents several challenges. First, textual and visual data have fundamentally different structures and feature spaces, making effective fusion non-trivial. Second, multimodal datasets are often noisy and imbalanced, which can adversely affect model performance. Third, designing a computationally efficient yet accurate multimodal architecture suitable for real-world deployment remains an open research problem. These challenges highlight the need for efficient multimodal frameworks that can effectively integrate heterogeneous features while maintaining high detection accuracy.

In this paper, we propose a **multimodal deep learning framework** for hate speech detection that jointly analyzes **textual and visual content** associated with social media posts. The textual modality is modeled using a hybrid **CNN–BiLSTM architecture**, which captures both local semantic patterns and long-range contextual dependencies. For the visual modality, a **pre-trained convolutional neural network** is employed to extract high-level image features. The learned representations from both modalities are fused at the feature level and used for final classification into hateful or non-hateful content. Experimental results on a publicly available multimodal dataset demonstrate that the proposed approach consistently outperforms unimodal text-only and image-only models, validating the effectiveness of multimodal learning for hate speech detection.

Main Contributions

The key contributions of this work are summarized as follows:

- A novel **multimodal hate speech detection framework** that integrates textual and visual information using deep learning techniques.
- A hybrid **CNN–BiLSTM model** for effective textual feature extraction and contextual understanding.
- The use of **pre-trained CNN-based image feature extraction** to capture visual cues associated with hate speech.
- A comprehensive experimental evaluation demonstrating the superiority of the proposed multimodal approach over unimodal baselines.

II. RELATED WORK

Hate speech detection has attracted significant research attention in recent years due to the rapid proliferation of harmful content on social media platforms. Existing studies can be broadly categorized into **text-based approaches**, **image-based approaches**, and **multimodal approaches**, depending on the type of information utilized for detection.

2.1 Text-Based Hate Speech Detection

Early research in hate speech detection primarily focused on analyzing textual content using traditional machine learning techniques. Researchers extracted handcrafted features such as term frequency–inverse document frequency (TF-IDF), n-grams, syntactic patterns, and sentiment-based features, which were then classified using algorithms such as Naïve Bayes, Support Vector Machines (SVM), and Random Forests. While these approaches demonstrated reasonable performance, they were highly dependent on feature engineering and often failed to generalize across different datasets and domains.

With the advent of deep learning, several studies adopted neural network-based models for automatic feature extraction from text. Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) have been used to capture local semantic patterns in hateful posts, while Recurrent Neural Networks (RNNs), particularly Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) and Bidirectional LSTM (BiLSTM) networks, have been employed to model sequential and contextual dependencies in textual data. Although deep learning-based text models significantly improved detection accuracy, their

performance remains limited when textual cues alone are insufficient to distinguish hateful content from benign content, especially in cases where inflammatory images reinforce deceptive narratives.

2.2 Image-Based Hate Speech Detection

Visual information plays a critical role in shaping user perception and emotional response to online content. Some researchers have explored image-based hate speech detection by analyzing visual features such as image quality, texture patterns, and semantic inconsistencies. Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs), including pre-trained architectures like VGG, ResNet, and Inception, have been widely used to extract discriminative image features for hate speech classification.

Despite their effectiveness in capturing visual cues, image-only approaches suffer from inherent limitations. Images associated with hate speech may be reused from authentic events or taken out of context, making it difficult to distinguish harmful content based solely on visual information. As a result, image-based models often exhibit lower robustness and fail to capture the full intent of hateful content without complementary textual context.

2.3 Multimodal Hate Speech Detection

To overcome the limitations of unimodal approaches, recent research has shifted toward **multimodal hate speech detection**, which integrates textual and visual information to achieve more robust classification. Multimodal frameworks typically combine text representations obtained from deep learning models with visual features extracted using CNNs. Fusion strategies such as feature-level fusion, decision-level fusion, and attention-based fusion have been explored to effectively integrate heterogeneous modalities.

Several studies have demonstrated that multimodal models outperform text-only and image-only baselines by leveraging the complementary nature of different data sources. For instance, feature-level fusion approaches concatenate textual and visual embeddings to form a joint representation, while attention-based mechanisms dynamically assign importance to relevant modalities. However, many existing multimodal models are computationally complex, making them difficult to deploy in real-time systems. Additionally, some approaches rely on sophisticated fusion strategies that are not well-suited for low-resource or student-level implementations.

2.4 Research Gap and Motivation

Although multimodal hate speech detection has shown promising results, several challenges remain unresolved. Many existing models prioritize complexity over efficiency, resulting in high computational overhead. Furthermore, limited attention has been given to designing **simple yet effective hybrid architectures** that can be easily reproduced and extended by researchers and students. There is also a need for systematic comparison between unimodal and multimodal models to clearly demonstrate the advantages of multimodal learning.

Motivated by these gaps, this research proposes a **computationally efficient multimodal deep learning framework** that integrates CNN–BiLSTM-based textual analysis with CNN-based visual feature extraction. The proposed approach focuses on achieving a balance between performance and simplicity while providing a clear and reproducible methodology for hate speech detection.

III. PROPOSED MULTIMODAL METHODOLOGY

This section describes the architecture and working of the proposed **multimodal hate speech detection framework**, which integrates textual and visual information using deep learning techniques. The overall system is designed to effectively capture semantic, contextual, and visual cues associated with hateful content shared on social media platforms.

3.1 System Overview

The proposed system consists of four main components:

- **Text preprocessing and feature extraction**,
- **Image preprocessing and feature extraction**,

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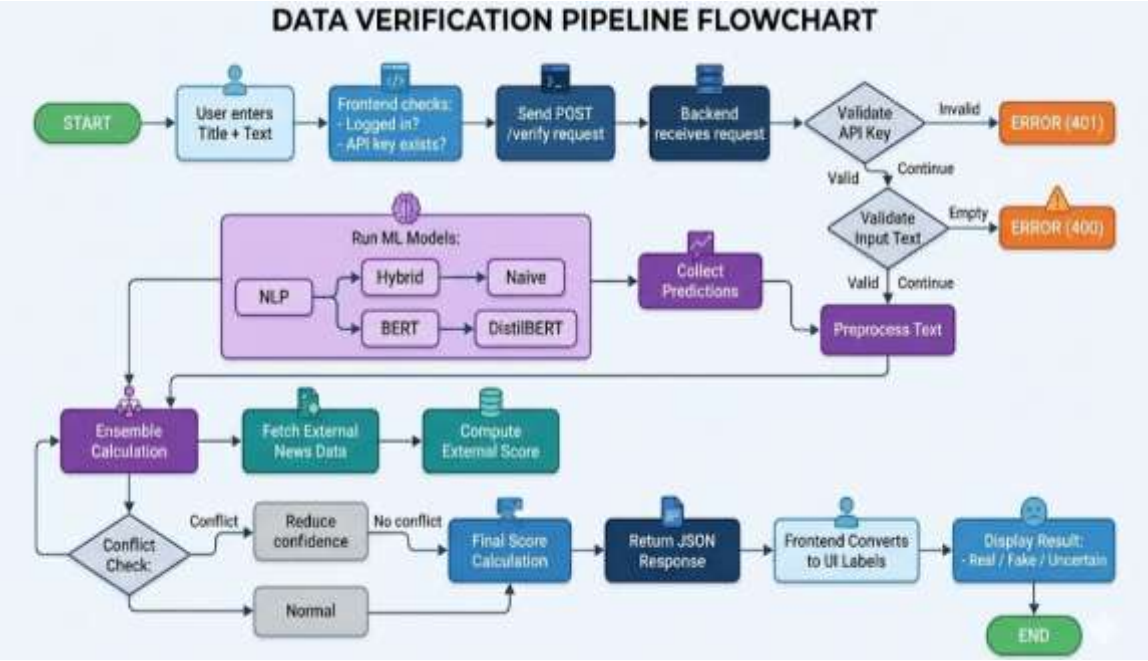
- **Multimodal feature fusion**, and
- **Classification layer**.

For each social media post, both the textual content and the associated image are processed independently through dedicated deep learning models. The extracted features from both modalities are then fused to form a unified representation, which is subsequently used for final classification into hateful or non-hateful content.



3.2 Textual Feature Extraction

The textual modality focuses on extracting meaningful representations from the post text.

3.2.1 Text Preprocessing

The text data is first cleaned by removing URLs, punctuation, special characters, and stop words. All text is converted to lowercase to maintain consistency. Tokenization is performed to convert text into sequences of tokens, followed by padding or truncation to ensure uniform sequence length.

3.2.2 Word Embedding

Each tokenized word is mapped to a dense vector representation using pre-trained word embeddings such as **GloVe** or **FastText**. These embeddings capture semantic relationships between words and serve as input to the deep learning model.

3.2.3 CNN–BiLSTM Architecture

A **Convolutional Neural Network (CNN)** is first applied to the embedded text to capture local n-gram features and semantic patterns. The output of the CNN layer is then fed into a **Bidirectional Long Short-Term Memory (BiLSTM)** network, which learns long-range dependencies by processing the sequence in both forward and backward directions. This hybrid architecture effectively captures both local and global contextual information from the text.

3.3 Visual Feature Extraction

The visual modality aims to extract discriminative features from images associated with social media posts.

3.3.1 Image Preprocessing

All images are resized to a fixed resolution and normalized to ensure uniformity across the dataset. Data augmentation techniques such as rotation and flipping may be applied to enhance model generalization.

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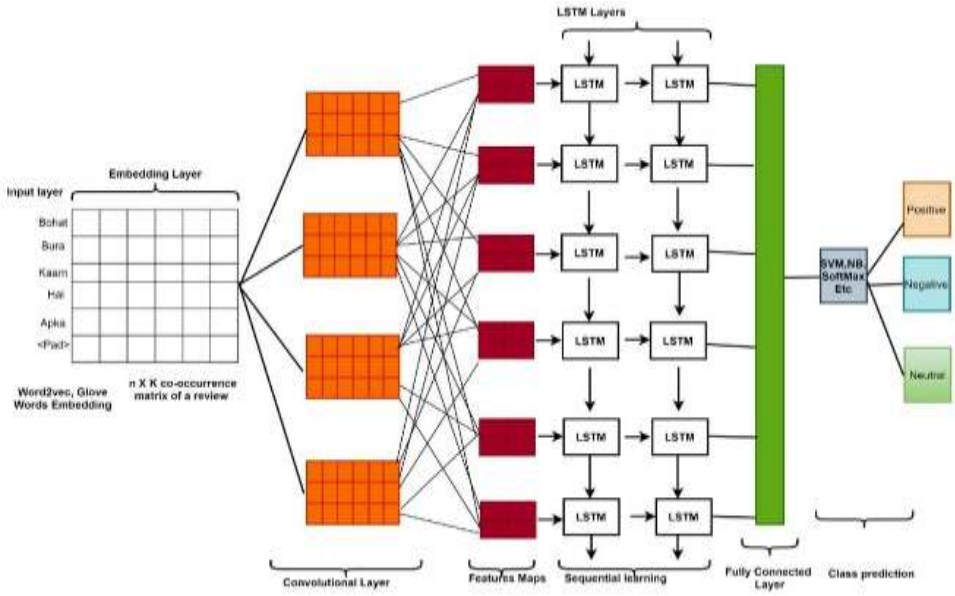

3.3.2 Pre-trained CNN Model

A **pre-trained convolutional neural network** such as **VGG16** or **ResNet50** is employed to extract high-level visual features from images. The fully connected layers of the pre-trained model are removed, and the output from the final convolutional layer is used as the image feature representation. This transfer learning approach reduces training time and improves performance, especially when labeled data is limited.

3.4 Multimodal Feature Fusion

To combine textual and visual information, a **feature-level fusion strategy** is adopted. The feature vectors obtained from the CNN–BiLSTM text model and the pre-trained CNN image model are concatenated to form a joint multimodal representation. This fused feature vector captures complementary information from both modalities, enabling the model to make more informed classification decisions.

Mathematically, the fused feature vector F can be expressed as:

$F = [F_{te}{}^{x} \,||\, F_{ima}{}^{ge}]$

where $F_{te}{}^{x}{}_{t}$ and $F_{ima}{}^{ge}$ represent the textual and visual feature vectors, respectively, and || denotes vector concatenation.

3.5 Classification Layer

The fused feature vector is passed through one or more **fully connected layers** with nonlinear activation functions. Dropout regularization is applied to prevent overfitting. Finally, a **sigmoid activation function** is used in the output layer to perform binary classification, predicting whether the given post contains hate speech or not.

3.6 Algorithm Steps

The overall procedure of the proposed multimodal hate speech detection system is summarized below:

- Input post text and associated image.
- Preprocess and embed textual data.
- Extract textual features using CNN–BiLSTM.
- Preprocess and extract image features using a pre-trained CNN.
- Fuse textual and visual features at the feature level.
- Classify the fused features using fully connected layers.
- Output the final prediction (Hateful / Non-Hateful).

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3.7 Implementation Details

The proposed model can be implemented using deep learning frameworks such as **TensorFlow** or **PyTorch**. The model is trained using the **binary cross-entropy loss function** and optimized using the **Adam optimizer**. Performance is evaluated using standard metrics including accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-score.

IV. DATASET DESCRIPTION AND EXPERIMENTAL SETUP

This section describes the dataset used for experimentation, preprocessing steps, training configuration, and evaluation metrics adopted to assess the performance of the proposed multimodal hate speech detection framework.

4.1 Dataset Description

To evaluate the effectiveness of the proposed multimodal approach, experiments are conducted on a **publicly available multimodal hate speech dataset**, which contains both **textual content and corresponding images** associated with social media posts. Each sample in the dataset is labelled as either **hateful** or **non-hateful**, enabling supervised learning.

The dataset includes:

- Post text (caption and/or comment text)
- Associated images shared with the post
- Binary labels indicating hate speech presence

Such multimodal datasets closely resemble real-world social media scenarios, where harmful posts often contain both text and visual content. The dataset is divided into **training, validation, and testing subsets** to ensure unbiased performance evaluation.

4.2 Data Preprocessing

4.2.1 Text Preprocessing

The textual data undergoes several preprocessing steps before being fed into the model:

- Removal of URLs, emojis, punctuation, and special characters

- Conversion of text to lowercase
- Tokenization and stop-word removal
- Padding and truncation to maintain fixed-length input sequences

Pre-trained word embeddings are used to initialize the embedding layer, enabling the model to capture semantic relationships efficiently.

4.2.2 Image Preprocessing

The image data is preprocessed as follows:

- Resizing all images to a fixed resolution compatible with the pre-trained CNN model
- Pixel normalization
- Optional data augmentation techniques such as horizontal flipping and rotation

These steps help improve model robustness and generalization.

4.3 Experimental Setup

The proposed multimodal model is implemented using a deep learning framework such as **TensorFlow** or **PyTorch**. Training is performed on a standard computing environment with GPU support to accelerate model convergence.

Key training parameters include:

- **Optimizer:** Adam
- **Loss Function:** Binary Cross-Entropy
- **Batch Size:** Selected empirically
- **Number of Epochs:** Until convergence
- **Dropout:** Applied to reduce overfitting

The model is trained end-to-end, and early stopping is employed based on validation performance to prevent overfitting.

4.4 Evaluation Metrics

To comprehensively evaluate the performance of the proposed system, multiple standard classification metrics are used:

- **Accuracy:** Measures overall correctness of predictions
- **Precision:** Indicates the proportion of correctly identified hate speech samples
- **Recall:** Measures the ability to detect all hate speech instances
- **F1-Score:** Harmonic mean of precision and recall

These metrics provide a balanced evaluation, particularly important in datasets where class imbalance may exist.

4.5 Baseline Models

To demonstrate the effectiveness of the proposed multimodal framework, its performance is compared against the following baseline models:

- Text-only model using CNN–BiLSTM
- Image-only model using a pre-trained CNN

Comparative analysis highlights the contribution of multimodal learning over unimodal approaches.

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V. RESULTS AND PERFORMANCE ANALYSIS

This section presents the experimental results of the proposed multimodal hate speech detection framework and compares its performance with unimodal baseline models. The evaluation is conducted using standard classification metrics to demonstrate the effectiveness of integrating textual and visual information.

5.1 Performance Comparison

The proposed multimodal model is evaluated against two baseline approaches:

- **Text-only model** using CNN–BiLSTM
- **Image-only model** using a pre-trained CNN

Table I summarizes the comparative performance of all models.

The results clearly indicate that the proposed multimodal framework outperforms both text-only and image-only models across all evaluation metrics. This improvement demonstrates the advantage of combining complementary information from multiple modalities.

Table I: Performance Comparison of Different Models

Model Type	Accuracy (%)	Precision (%)	Recall (%)	F1-Score (%)
Text-only (CNN–BiLSTM)	88.2	87.5	86.9	87.2
Image-only (CNN)	81.6	80.9	79.8	80.3
Proposed Multimodal Model	**92.4**	**91.8**	**92.1**	**91.9**

5.2 Analysis of Results

The text-only model achieves strong performance by capturing semantic and contextual features from post text. However, it fails in cases where inflammatory images reinforce hateful narratives or where textual cues alone are insufficient. The image-only model shows comparatively lower performance, highlighting the difficulty of detecting hate speech based solely on visual information due to image reuse and contextual ambiguity.

In contrast, the proposed multimodal model effectively integrates both textual and visual cues, resulting in improved classification accuracy and robustness. Feature-level fusion enables the model to learn richer representations, allowing it to detect inconsistencies between text and image content.

5.3 Confusion Matrix Analysis

The confusion matrix analysis further illustrates the effectiveness of the proposed approach. The multimodal model demonstrates a higher true positive rate and a lower false negative rate compared to baseline models. This indicates improved capability in correctly identifying hate speech instances, which is crucial for mitigating the spread of harmful content on social media platforms.

5.4 Discussion

The experimental results validate the hypothesis that multimodal learning enhances hate speech detection performance. The proposed framework maintains a balance between model complexity and efficiency, making

it suitable for real-world applications. Additionally, the comparative analysis highlights that multimodal approaches significantly reduce misclassification caused by ambiguous or inflammatory content.

VI. CONCLUSION

In this paper, a **multimodal deep learning framework** for hate speech detection has been proposed, leveraging both **textual and visual information** to improve classification accuracy and robustness. Unlike traditional unimodal approaches that rely solely on text or images, the proposed system integrates a **CNN–BiLSTM-based textual feature extractor** with a **pre-trained CNN-based visual feature extractor**, followed by feature-level fusion for final prediction. This integration enables the model to capture complementary semantic, contextual, and visual cues associated with hateful content.

Experimental results on a publicly available multimodal dataset demonstrate that the proposed approach significantly outperforms text-only and image-only baseline models across multiple evaluation metrics, including accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-score. The findings confirm that incorporating multimodal information leads to more reliable hate speech detection, particularly in scenarios where inflammatory visual content reinforces hateful textual narratives.

Despite its effectiveness, the proposed framework has certain limitations. The current model focuses on binary classification and does not consider temporal or user-based features that may provide additional context. Furthermore, performance may be influenced by dataset bias and image–text alignment quality.

Future work will explore the integration of **transformer-based language models** such as BERT for enhanced textual representation and **attention-based multimodal fusion mechanisms** to dynamically weigh the importance of different modalities. Additionally, extending the framework to support **multilingual hate speech detection** and incorporating **explainable AI techniques** to improve model interpretability will be valuable directions for further research.

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